ONLINE SPEECH

Russian Federation v. Alexander Pichugin

9 October 2026

CASE FOLLOW-UP REPORT

Procedural developments and verified outcomes

Independent research based on user-supplied TrialWatch materials

ABOUT THIS UPDATE

This independent research update follows the user-supplied TrialWatch material. It is not issued by the Clooney Foundation for Justice, TrialWatch, or the original authors. The earlier report supplies the historical baseline; later developments are supported by the sources cited here.

Jurisdiction	Russian Federation
Original report	April 2022
Dated update covered	13 November 2025
Research cutoff	9 October 2026
Historical assessment	TrialWatch grade D (original report only)

SCOPE AND METHOD

Research considered public court records, enacted legislation, lawyers and subjects, press-freedom organizations, United Nations materials and attributable reporting available through 9 October 2026. Publication dates and event dates are distinguished. Where judgments or current custody records could not be obtained, the conclusion is expressly qualified. No direct interviews or new trial monitoring were conducted for this update.

An acquittal, quashing order, pardon, sentence completion, bail decision and custody transfer have different legal effects. A reported intention to litigate is separated from an actual filing. Unresolved questions are listed below. Historical TrialWatch grades retain their original attribution; this update does not assign a new grade.

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

LATEST VERIFIED POSITION

ECtHR found freedom-of-expression violation; domestic reversal and payment unverified

The ECtHR's final committee judgment addresses the original speech conviction and a separate protest case. The EUR 10,000 award covers the applicant's combined findings, not exclusively the speech prosecution. A foreign-agent designation on 7 November 2025 is separately reported. No new prison sentence, domestic acquittal, or payment of the Strasbourg award was verified.

On 13 November 2025, the European Court of Human Rights ruled in Pichugin's favor in Vlasov and Others v. Russia. His representing Media Defence Centre explains that the judgment addressed both the COVID-19 satire prosecution and a distinct protest-related case, with EUR 10,000 awarded. This is the latest verified judicial event identified. [4]

A separate development preceded that judgment: the Justice Ministry added the Nizhny Novgorod journalist to the foreign-agent register on 7 November 2025. That designation is not a terrorism-list entry or another sentence under the provision used in the original report. [5]

4. Media Defence Centre (MMDC), 13 November 2025. ECtHR rules in case of Nizhny Novgorod journa...

5. Kommersant, 7 November 2025. Nizhny Novgorod journalist Alexander Pichugin...

BACKGROUND AND PROCEDURAL HISTORY

The supplied April 2022 report concerns journalist Alexander Pichugin, also transliterated Aleksandr, and his Telegram channel Sorokin Khvost. It is not the case of imprisoned former Yukos employee Alexey Pichugin. The subject and channel, the 300,000-ruble fine, and counsel's identity provide safeguards against that consequential name confusion. [1]

The prosecution arose from a satirical 12 April 2020 post criticizing church gatherings during the COVID-19 pandemic. Under Article 207.1, authorities treated the commentary as knowingly false information about a public threat. On 11 November 2020, the Bogorodsk City Court convicted Pichugin and imposed a 300,000-ruble fine. It did not impose a custodial sentence. The TrialWatch monitoring covered proceedings from July to November 2020. [1]

TrialWatch expert Oliver Wallasch assigned the historical grade D. The report identified shortcomings in proof of intent, treatment of linguistic evidence and reasoning, including the handling of evidence supporting a metaphorical reading of the post. It also assessed the interference with freedom of expression. Those are the original report's findings, not a fresh grading exercise or a claim that later courts adopted every TrialWatch criticism. [1]

KEY PROCEDURAL DATES

11 November 2020	Bogorodsk City Court convicted Pichugin and imposed a 300,000-ruble fine. [1]
26 January 2021	Nizhny Novgorod Regional Court upheld the fine. [2]
13 October 2021	Application No. 51945/21 lodged at the ECtHR. [3]
10 February 2022	Supreme Court decision identified in the ECtHR appendix as final domestic decision in the speech case. [3]
7 November 2025	Justice Ministry foreign-agent designation reported. [5]
13 November 2025	Final ECtHR judgment; combined EUR 10,000 award. [3] [4]

1. User-supplied original report, April 2022.
2. Zhurnalist, 27 January 2021. Fine against journalist Alexander Pichugin up...
3. European Court of Human Rights, 13 November 2025. Vlasov and Others v. Russia, applications 193...
4. Media Defence Centre (MMDC), 13 November 2025. ECtHR rules in case of Nizhny Novgorod journa...
5. Kommersant, 7 November 2025. Nizhny Novgorod journalist Alexander Pichugin...

SUBSEQUENT DEVELOPMENTS

Contemporaneous reporting confirms that the regional appeal was rejected on 26 January 2021. Counsel Tumas Misakyan then intended to pursue cassation and Strasbourg proceedings. An announced intention alone would not establish filing; the later ECtHR appendix supplies the application number and actual introduction date. [2] [3]

The ECtHR found disproportionate interference with Article 10 in the satire prosecution and expressly states that its committee judgment is final. [3]

The representing lawyers describe separate protest-related findings under Articles 5, 6 and 11, alongside the speech finding. The EUR 10,000 award covers the combined complaints rather than the original prosecution alone. [4]

The lawyer organization's same-day account independently ties the European decision to the journalist and original post. It explains the combined rights findings and compensation award, reinforcing identification while not proving that the award was paid or that Russian courts removed the conviction. [4]

Kommersant's November 2025 report connects the foreign-agent designation to the same journalist and the COVID satire conviction. It also reports that he had lived outside Russia since 2022. That is a dated account of relocation, not verification of his residence or legal security on 9 October 2026. The government's allegations associated with designation should not be treated as established facts. [5]

LEGAL AND PROCEDURAL ASSESSMENT

The following assessment draws inferences from the cited record. It does not represent a new court finding or TrialWatch grade.

the speech finding supports TrialWatch's expression concern, but does not establish that every original fairness criticism was separately upheld. [1] [3]

an international victory and a later designation answer different questions. Neither establishes domestic expungement, payment, present liberty or a new terrorism case. [3] [5]

1. User-supplied original report, April 2022.
2. Zhurnalist, 27 January 2021. Fine against journalist Alexander Pichugin up...
3. European Court of Human Rights, 13 November 2025. Vlasov and Others v. Russia, applications 193...
4. Media Defence Centre (MMDC), 13 November 2025. ECtHR rules in case of Nizhny Novgorod journa...
5. Kommersant, 7 November 2025. Nizhny Novgorod journalist Alexander Pichugin...

CONCLUSION AND OUTSTANDING RECORDS

The final ECtHR judgment is the strongest verified update. Domestic implementation remains unresolved; foreign-agent designation is a distinct event. [3] [5]

RECORDS NOT VERIFIED

1. Was the Article 207.1 conviction subsequently reopened, quashed, or expunged domestically?

2. Was the EUR 10,000 ECtHR award paid, and through what mechanism?

3. Has the 7 November 2025 foreign-agent designation been challenged or removed?

4. Are there any later case-specific restrictions or proceedings, confirmed by counsel or court documents, through the cutoff?

Failure to locate an update leaves a gap in the available evidence; it does not establish that no later proceeding or change occurred. Any present-status claim should be read with the dated scope stated in the executive summary.

3. European Court of Human Rights, 13 November 2025. Vlasov and Others v. Russia, applications 193...

5. Kommersant, 7 November 2025. Nizhny Novgorod journalist Alexander Pichugin...

SOURCES AND REFERENCES

Numbered references correspond to superscript citations and page notes. Web sources were consulted for this research through 9 October 2026. Original reports are local user-supplied files. Each link opens the cited source.

1. **Original user-supplied report on Russian Federation v. Alexander Pichugin**
TrialWatch / original report authors. April 2022.
Local PDF: russian-federation-vs-alexander-pichugin.pdf
Coverage: Historical case baseline and original assessment

2. **Fine against journalist Alexander Pichugin upheld on appeal**
Zhurnalist. 27 January 2021.
Read source at jrnlst.ru
Coverage: Regional appeal rejected 26 January 2021; counsel's intended further applications, not proof of filing.

3. **Vlasov and Others v. Russia, applications 1930/20 and three others**
European Court of Human Rights; judgment reproduced by Czech Ministry of Justice / Office of Government Agent. 13 November 2025.
Read source at mezisoudy.cz
Coverage: Appendix row 3: Pichugin, application 51945/21, introduced 13 October 2021; Supreme Court decision 10 February 2022; speech/protest findings and combined award.

4. **ECtHR rules in case of Nizhny Novgorod journalist convicted of fake news**
Media Defence Centre (MMDC). 13 November 2025.
Read source at mmdc.ru
Coverage: Confirms identity, original satire prosecution, separate protest complaints and EUR 10,000 award.

5. **Nizhny Novgorod journalist Alexander Pichugin designated a foreign agent**
Kommersant. 7 November 2025.
Read source at www.kommersant.ru
Coverage: 7 November 2025 designation of the same journalist; reported departure in 2022.